The Deal with Disinformation

Podcast

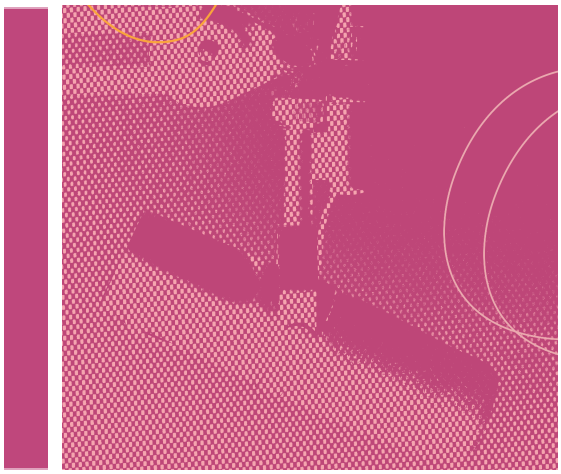
Summary

In an engaging discussion on misinformation and disinformation, Professor James Wright of the University of Alberta, highlights the critical distinction between the two. Misinformation, he explains, is simply inaccurate information, while disinformation is deliberately false content designed to mislead. In *The Deal with Disinformation*, Wright, an Associate Professor of Computer Science, shares insights on how disinformation affects society today and emphasizes that its roots lie less in technology itself and more in the incentive structures that drive online platforms.

An "incentive problem" occurs when rewards or consequences encourage unfavorable behavior. In the context of social media, business models and algorithms are designed to maximize engagement. Because disinformation is often sensational and attention-grabbing (attracting views, likes, shares, and comments), it is frequently amplified by platform algorithms. This creates a fundamental misalignment between what's best for the platform and what's best for the public. While platforms benefit financially from engagement, the cost becomes the overall public good of a well-informed society.

To research this complex issue, Wright and his team apply game theory to model the dynamics of disinformation and explore potential solutions. Their findings reveal that solutions are far from simple. For example, external regulations like fact-checking measures or fines were found to lose effectiveness over time. In fact, research suggests that such interventions only work when backed by punishments so severe that they amount to costly "overreactions," which are not practical or ideal.

A more promising approach discussed is rethinking the incentive structures behind today's platforms. Instead of relying solely on external regulation measures, solutions must address the business models that fuel disinformation. This could mean moving away from advertising-driven revenue toward subscription-based services, or developing entirely new systems designed to build trust and reward accuracy. Ultimately, the goal is to create a digital environment where the interests of platforms and users align by promoting honest information instead of sensationalized disinformation.



Key Terms

Term	Definition
Misinformation	Information that is false or incorrect, regardless of the intent behind its spread.
Disinformation	Information that is deliberately false and spread with the intention to deceive.
Incentive Problem	Occurs when rewards or consequences lead to behavior that is not in the best interest of the intended goal, often resulting in unethical actions, poor outcomes or unintended consequences.
Agent	An entity that gathers information from its surroundings and acts to achieve a goal.
Game Theory	A branch of applied mathematics and a framework for understanding strategic decision-making where outcomes depend on the choice of multiple "players".
Behavioral Game Theory	A subfield of game theory that incorporates psychological insights to explain how people actually make strategic decisions, rather than just assuming perfect rationality.
Engagement	The level of user interaction with content on social media platforms (e.g., likes, shares, comments, and time spent viewing). This is the key business metric for many platforms.
Externalities	The costs or benefits of an action that affect a party who did not choose to take that action.
Misinformation	Information that is false or incorrect, regardless of the intent behind its spread.

3 Key Takeaways

1. Disinformation thrives in our current digital ecosystem because it is often sensationalized and attention-grabbing.
2. Research shows imposing regulations like fact-checking and fines lose effectiveness over time unless punishments are extreme, which results in them being impractical and not ideal.
3. Real solutions are going to require addressing the incentive models behind the scenes, and creating alternatives systems.

Discussion Questions

1. How does disinformation affect our communities, elections or even mental health?

2. Wright mentions how in the past, after new information technology emerged (like the printing press), how society eventually solved the propaganda problem by developing trusted sources or "gatekeepers" like reputable news organizations. Do you think a similar solution is possible for social media platforms? What fundamental differences could cause challenges?

Relevant Resources

Professor James Wright's has co-authored several papers that explore these topics:

- Disinformation, Stochastic Harm, and Costly Effort: A Principal-Agent Analysis of Regulating Social Media Platforms

  https://scholar.google.com/citations?view_op=view_citation&hl=en&user=-BEP3TYAAAAJ&citation_for_view=-BEP3TYAAAAJ:W7OEmFMy1HYC

- Level-0 Models for Predicting Human Behavior in Games

  https://scholar.google.com/citations?view_op=view_citation&hl=en&user=-BEP3TYAAAAJ&cstart=20&pagesize=80&citation_for_view=-BEP3TYAAAAJ:qUcmZB5y_30C

References

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